In the 1880s, however, the key to a new form of renewable energy was provided by American inventor Charles Fritts—a photovoltaic cell, which could convert solar power to electricity. German industrialist Werner von Siemens soon saw its potential for producing limitless energy, but it took a century for solar power to be widely adopted. “Clean” hydroelectric power was the first sustainable source capable of generating electricity on a large scale—joined in the late 20th century by modern wind power, and tidal, wave, and geothermal energy.

An environmental ethic

In 1937, following the devastating “Dust Bowl” caused by intensive farming in the US, President Franklin D. Roosevelt wrote, “A nation that destroys its soils destroys itself.” In 1949, American ecologist and forester Aldo Leopold articulated a recurring theme in environmental thought, by advocating a “land ethic,” a responsible relationship between people and their local environment.

The post-war period saw many governments legislating to ensure the quality of air and drinking water and establish national parks and other protected areas. In 1968, the world first found its collective voice, when UNESCO (the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization) held the Paris Biosphere Conference. This resulted, three years later, in the creation of the Man and the Biosphere Programme.

Growing awareness

Public concern for the environment was marked by the establishment of major conservation organizations. The International Union for the Conservation of Nature had been established in 1948, and it was followed by the World Wildlife Fund (1961), Friends of the Earth (1969), and Greenpeace (1971). After the 1969 massive oil spill in Santa Barbara,